Elements of Fiction

My Creative Writing reviewer! Fiction is a narrative made up by the writer, even if it feels real. Every story uses the same core elements. To make it easier, I will use one original story idea all throughout.

Our sample story idea: "Sagwan"

Jomar is a 16-year-old in a small fishing barangay in Samar. He has just won a scholarship to a science high school in Manila, but his father's old bangka is falling apart, and the family depends on his help at sea. On the night before the enrollment deadline, a storm signal is raised while his father is still out fishing. Jomar takes his late lolo's wooden paddle, the sagwan, and goes to find him.

Character

Characters are the people, animals, or beings who act in the story.

- Protagonist: the main character the story follows. Here it is Jomar.
- Antagonist: the force or character that blocks the protagonist. It does not always have to be a villain. In "Sagwan," the storm and Jomar's own fear work against him.
- Round character: complex, with many sides, like Jomar, who loves his family but also dreams of leaving.
- Flat character: has only one or two traits, like a cheerful neighbor who appears once.
- Dynamic character: changes by the end of the story. Static character: stays the same.

Writers reveal characters in two ways. Direct characterization tells us outright ("Jomar was stubborn"). Indirect characterization shows it through speech, actions, thoughts, looks, and how others react.

Setting

Setting is where and when the story happens. It includes the place, the time (hour, season, or historical period), and the social environment, such as the community's beliefs and economic situation. In our story, the setting is a coastal barangay in Samar during typhoon season, in a community where many families live on day-to-day fishing income.

Plot and its parts

Plot is the planned sequence of events in a story. A common way to map it is Freytag's pyramid:

- Exposition: introduces the characters, setting, and situation. We meet Jomar, his father, and the scholarship letter.
- Rising action: complications build tension. The bangka leaks, his father insists Jomar must go to Manila, and the storm warning is announced.
- Climax: the turning point and moment of highest tension. Jomar paddles out in the rain and finds his father's boat drifting.
- Falling action: events after the climax start to settle. They struggle back to shore together.
- Resolution or denouement: loose ends are tied up. His father hands him the sagwan and tells him to bring it to Manila.

Conflict

Conflict is the struggle that pushes the plot forward. Without conflict, there is no story.

- Internal conflict happens inside a character's mind. Character vs. self: Jomar torn between his dream and his duty.
- External conflict is with an outside force:
- Character vs. character: a clash between two people, like Jomar arguing with his father.
- Character vs. nature: the storm and the sea.
- Character vs. society: going against a community's norms or system, like poverty that limits choices.

Point of view

Point of view is the position from which the story is told.

- First person: the narrator is a character and uses "I." Jomar could tell the story himself.
- Second person: uses "you," placing the reader inside the story. This is rare.
- Third person limited: uses "he" or "she" and follows the thoughts of only one character.
- Third person omniscient: the narrator knows the thoughts of all characters.
- Third person objective: the narrator reports only what can be seen and heard, like a camera.

Theme

Theme is the central idea or insight about life the story suggests. It is different from the topic. The topic of "Sagwan" is family and poverty, but the theme could be stated as a full sentence: "Leaving home to chase a dream does not have to mean abandoning the people we love." Themes are usually implied, not announced.

Tone and mood

These two are easy to mix up.

- Tone is the writer's attitude toward the subject, shown through word choice. The tone of "Sagwan" might be tender and hopeful.
- Mood is the feeling the story creates in the reader. During the storm scene, the mood is tense and anxious.

Symbolism

A symbol is a concrete object, person, or event that stands for a bigger idea beyond its literal meaning. In our story, the sagwan stands for family heritage and the strength passed from one generation to the next. When Jomar's father gives it to him, it shows that Jomar can carry home with him wherever he goes.

Quick check

- Q: What is the turning point of the plot called? A: The climax.
- Q: What type of conflict is a character struggling with his own fears? A: Internal conflict, or character vs. self.
- Q: How is theme different from topic? A: Topic is the subject in a word or phrase; theme is the message about life, stated as a full sentence.
- Q: What is the difference between tone and mood? A: Tone is the writer's attitude; mood is the feeling the reader gets.

- Q: Which point of view lets the narrator know every character's thoughts? A: Third person omniscient.